

EYEWITNESS January 31, 1968

Tet Offensive

As the Tet Offensive exploded across South Vietnam, Saigon came under intense attack from Viet Cong units. Among their foremost targets was the compound of the US Embassy, held by a small contingent of military police and Marines with the help of a handful of embassy staff. Diplomat Allan Wendt recalls how he reacted when he was woken by the attack.

“All of a sudden at about 2:00 in the morning, 2:30 I guess—I was sound asleep—and there was an enormous explosion and the tinkling of masonry all around ... Rockets were thudding into the building. It was all bedlam ... I called the Marine Guard, and he confirmed what I had begun to suspect—that the embassy was under a full-scale assault ... he estimated that there were about 20 Viet Cong guerillas. They blew open the wall, and they poured into the compound ... and started firing rockets and AK-47 assault rifles into the building ...

I started making phone calls ... to the military assistance command ... to Washington. I spoke to the Situation Room in the White House. I spoke to the Operations Center in the State Department ... I was on the phone constantly with our military command headquarters at Tan Son Nhut airport, pleading with them for relief. And I pointed out that the American Embassy is ‘the citadel’ of the American presence in Vietnam. And for it to be in the hands of a Viet Cong guerrilla squad did not look good ... ”

US EMBASSY OFFICER ALLAN WENDT, VIDEO TRANSCRIPT FROM THE ASSOCIATION FOR DIPLOMATIC STUDIES & TRAINING, 1968